

Session 22: Paul Summarizes His Message (Eph. 3:1-13)

Key Takeaways

- When the new humanity gets together, disregarding the boundary lines of identity that keep them apart, they become God’s wisdom incarnate.
- Paul's boasting is always in the context of the upside-down value system of the Kingdom.

The Mystery of the New Creation Family: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 3:1-13

¹ For this reason, I Paul, the prisoner
of the Messiah Jesus
on behalf of y'all the nations —

² if indeed y'all have heard
of the arranged plan
of the grace of God
which was given to me
for y'all,
³ that it would be made known to me
according to revelation
at the open-secret,
just as I earlier wrote about in brief,
⁴ into which you are,
after reading,
able to comprehend my **insight**
into the open-secret
of the Messiah,
⁵ which in other generations
was not made known
to the sons of humanity
as it is now revealed
by the Spirit

Ephesians 3:1-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Flow of Thought in 3:1-13

Paul is about to pray, but his designation as “Paul the prisoner” prompts a discussion of how his imprisonment highlights God’s grace and triumph in the Messiah, instead of bringing shame and suspicion to his message.

Ephesians 3:1: Paul interrupts his prayer.

Ephesians 3:2-7: God’s cosmic plan to unite humanity in the Messiah was not made known fully to previous generations, but as chapters 1-2 make clear, Paul has been given apocalyptic insight into God’s open-secret to include all nations in the Messiah’s family and the divine power in order to spread this message.

Ephesians 3:8-13: Paul is the least qualified person to have been selected for this task (“I’m the least of all the holy ones!”), and his mission has two facets.

- Ephesians 3:8: He is to travel and share the good news with as many people as possible.
- Ephesians 3:9-10: He is to “bring to light” the open-secret of the creator God, that he is creating a new humanity who is not captive to the spiritual-social forces that seek to divide humans into competing and hostile groups. God’s wisdom is to use the crucified Messiah announced by a prisoner to overturn the powers that be.
- Ephesians 3:11-13: Paul’s imprisonment is not shameful but a sign of the power of the good news to challenge the powers.

“In the face of the powers and authorities ... whose rule over this present evil age is characterized by destruction, division, and leading humanity astray into idolatry, God’s power is demonstrated by his ability to create the ‘new humanity’ (Eph 4:24), and to set it in the midst of enemy territory, thus confounding the evil powers ... Paul is not here charging the church with the task of preaching to the powers ... Rather, he is claiming that God has made known his multi-faceted plan. The powers have ordered the present evil age in such a way as to exacerbate the divisions within humanity created by the Law (2:11-12). God confounds the powers, however, by creating in Christ one unified, multi-racial body consisting of formerly divided groups of people. The mere existence of the church as such a body set within the hostile environment of the present evil age proclaims the wisdom of God.”

Gombis, Timothy G. (2004). “Ephesians 3:2–13: Pointless Digression, Or Epitome Of The Triumph Of God In Christ?” *Westminster Theological Journal* (Fall). 320-322.

“[Paul] exults in his present occupation of a shameful, weak, and humiliating position. He glories in his imprisonment, calling himself ‘Paul the prisoner.’ Further, he claims that it was specifically to him as the one who is ‘less than the least of all the saints’ (ἐμοί τῷ ἐλαχιστοτέρῳ πάντων αγίων) that this grace was given (v. 8a), stressing his own unworthiness and lack of fitness for the task. Paul emphasizes his utter weakness and inability so that the triumph of God in Christ might clearly be seen. If Paul were in a position of political strength or earthly power, the clarity of this display to the evil powers might, in some measure, be diminished. Paul, therefore, highlights his humiliation and weakness.”

Gombis, Timothy G. (2004). "Ephesians 3:2–13: Pointless Digression, Or Epitome Of The Triumph Of God In Christ?" *Westminster Theological Journal* (Fall). 317

To his ancient audience, Paul's imprisonment would have been a source of suspicion and shame, so Paul needs to reframe his position for his readers. The apocalyptic perspective reverses the social value of Paul's imprisonment. It is precisely through his low position that God's honor in defeating the powers is highlighted, much like David's small size and low social status increases God's reputation in his defeat of Goliath (1 Sam. 17).

Reflection Question

Instead of being a status of shame, Paul considers his imprisonment to be "your [the Ephesians'] glory" (Eph. 3:13). Paul's greatest honor is found in his suffering and ability to share and participate in Jesus' suffering. In what ways is this different or similar to your culture's value systems?